CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Saturday, October 31, 2026

2,122 words · 8 min read

RE: Australia gifts Bluebottle drones to Fiji · Pacific drug seizures hit 17 tonnes · NFP to vote down Fiji Constitution Bill · Albanese calls RBA hikes a 'blunt instrument' · Ukraine joins PIF as sectoral partner

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,908	0.7035	13,797	0.5633
+1.28%	+0.07%	+0.36%	-1.21%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire · Analysis

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Australia is donating Bluebottle uncrewed surface vessels to Fiji under the $600 million Waqa Moana maritime security initiative, as Pacific drug seizures reach 17 tonnes since January against about 4.6 tonnes for all of 2025.
2. Fiji's National Federation Party has directed its MPs to vote against the Constitution (Amendment) Bill at third reading, while the People's Alliance says it has the numbers and the Vanua ko Lau presses for a senatorial veto over iTaukei land law.
3. Anthony Albanese called Reserve Bank rate rises a blunt instrument days before an expected tightening, and declined to pose for a G20 family photo alongside Russia's foreign minister.

TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Australia gifts Bluebottle drone vessels to Fiji as Pacific drug seizures surge

Australia is donating an unspecified number of Bluebottle uncrewed surface vessels to Fiji under the *$600 million* Pacific-led, Australian-supported Waqa Moana maritime security initiative, with the first expected next year. The Australian Federal Police say 17 tonnes of illicit drugs, mostly cocaine, have been seized in the Pacific since January, against about 4.6 tonnes for all of 2025. Fiji's Defence Minister **Pio Tikoduadua** said the country's waters are too large to watch with its two Australian-donated Guardian-class patrol boats, RFNS Savenaca and RFNS Timo. Vessel numbers are being kept vague deliberately.

per Australian Defence Magazine: "Fiji gifted Bluebottle USVs"

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Transparency win reopens fight over Australia's 2004 Timor-Leste bugging operation

Former senator **Rex Patrick** has won a ruling advancing his campaign to obtain documents on the 2004 mission in which Australian spies allegedly bugged Timor-Leste during oil and gas negotiations. The operation became a public scandal years later when a former intelligence officer and a former attorney-general attempted to mount a case in The Hague. Patrick describes it as the most open secret in the history of Australian spying.

per Guardian AU politics (Sarah Basford Canales): "A top-secret spy mission, a decades-old scandal – and the Austin Powers-esque saga to lift the lid"

AU-POLITICS

Albanese calls RBA rate rises a 'blunt instrument' with tightening expected

Anthony Albanese publicly distanced Labor from the Reserve Bank, describing rate increases as a blunt instrument as the bank prepares to lift the cash rate. He spoke candidly about what the Herald called a treacherous domestic and global political environment. A companion analysis described the criticism as calculated populism designed to show households he is on their side rather than that of faceless bankers.

per SMH Federal Politics (Paul Sakkal): "Albanese distances Labor from RBA, calls rate hikes a ‘blunt instrument’"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji's NFP directs MPs to vote against Constitution Bill at third reading

The National Federation Party has issued a directive that its MPs will vote against the Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026 at third reading. The People's Alliance says it is confident it has the numbers. Deputy Prime Minister **Manoa Kamikamica** told the Tailevu Provincial Council the amendments restore the iTaukei people to their rightful place in the supreme law, including a revived Senate and a role for the Bose Levu Vakaturaga in electing the President and Vice-President.

per Fijivillage: "NFP will not support Constitution Bill in third reading, MPs issued directive" · also Fiji Sun

OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

G20 ministers skip family photo after Australia objects to Lavrov · ABC Politics

Foreign ministers dropped the traditional group photograph at the G20 after about a third of participants, including Australia and Canada, objected to being pictured with Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov. A spokesperson for **Penny Wong** said Australia supports the decision of the United States as host, and that Australia's focus remains on the challenges facing the global economy.

AU-DEFENSE

Spy agency admits it was disclosing secrets through a tender website · The Australian

An Australian intelligence agency has admitted it was handing material to adversaries through a government tender site, The Australian reported. The published account gives no further detail on the agency, the period, or the material involved.

AU-DEFENSE

Lockheed Martin partners on hypersonic launch capability · Australian Defence Magazine

Lockheed Martin has entered a partnership on hypersonic launch capability, Australian Defence Magazine reported. No contract value or Australian industry partner is named in the published account.

AU-DEFENSE

Kapooka recruit base to get $846.9 million rebuild through 2033 · ABC News

Work has begun on an *$846.9 million* redevelopment of Blamey Barracks at Kapooka near Wagga Wagga, where every Australian Army recruit trains. More than 300,000 personnel have passed through the gates since the base was established as the Army's training facility in 1951. The redevelopment is expected to be complete in 2033 and will reuse materials from demolished buildings.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

DFAT works to confirm welfare of two Australians after Spanish rail disaster · SMH World

The Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade is providing consular assistance to the family of two Australians caught in a collision between two high-speed trains in Spain. The ABC reported the crash claimed at least *69 lives*.

AU-POLITICS

Canberra raises student visa costs and cuts working holiday maker places · The Diplomat

The government has increased international student visa charges and reduced working holiday maker allocations, The Diplomat reported. The piece frames the move as a response to voters drifting toward One Nation, with students and backpackers the easiest targets for a visible immigration measure.

STAT OF THE DAY

17 tonnes

Pacific illicit drug seizures since January 2026

The Australian Federal Police figure is close to four times the roughly 4.6 tonnes seized across the whole of 2025, and underpins the Bluebottle donation to Fiji.

Australian Defence Magazine

PACIFIC WIRE

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG task force traces smuggling network after Port Moresby artillery find

A joint police and Papua New Guinea Defence Force task force is investigating a suspected military artillery shell allegedly removed from a shipping container at Napa Napa Wharf and taken to a residential Port Moresby suburb. Police say the device has not been fired or detonated and dismissed claims it was a dummy, pending assessment by explosives experts.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu police monitoring 'Second Republic Movement'

The Vanuatu Police Force is closely monitoring activities tied to the so-called Second Republic Movement, reportedly associated with Louis Kalnpel, who was arrested after an unauthorised public demonstration on Santo in July.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu spends more than VT30 million on Pacific's largest trafficking case

The State has spent more than *VT30 million* on what the Daily Post describes as the largest documented human trafficking and slavery case in the Pacific, involving 107 Bangladeshis brought to Vanuatu by Sekdar Somon, also known as "Mr. Price".

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Lau chiefs call clause 50 the heart of Fiji's constitutional bill

The Vanua ko Lau told the Special Committee on the Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026 that clause 50 is the most important provision in the legislation and must not be diluted. Under it, changes to the iTaukei Lands Act, iTaukei Land Trust Act and iTaukei Affairs Act would require the agreement of nine of the 14 senators nominated by the Bose Levu Vakaturaga, with the same protection for Rotuman laws.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Church body opposes removing Fiji's referendum requirement

Apostles Fellowship International president **Penioni Ravunawa**, also Assistant Minister for Health and Medical Services, opposed proposed clause 209, which would remove the requirement for a national referendum on future constitutional amendments. Speaking at Kilaka Village in Kubulau, Bua, he said the organisation supports the Supreme Court's interpretation requiring two-thirds of all MPs plus approval by a majority of registered voters.

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

Samoan arrivals from Australia fall 13 percent in the third quarter

The Samoa Bureau of Statistics recorded 11,591 visitors from Australia between July and September, *1,775 fewer* than a year earlier and a drop of more than 13 percent from Samoa's second-largest market. New Zealand arrivals rose by 2,964 to 27,802, lifting the quarterly total 5.4 percent to 54,944. The bureau gave no explanation for the Australian decline.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Pa Enua executive officers draw up six-month island action plans

Executive officers from the Pa Enua met on Rarotonga for the Pa Enua Island Government Executive Officers Intersessional Forum, working through island priorities, governance, energy security, and workforce development.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu forecasts dry conditions to March 2027 and up to five cyclones

Vanuatu Meteorological and Hydrological Services director **Levu Antfalo** said El Nino will keep conditions dry until March 2027. A separate forecast puts the 2026-2027 season at three to five tropical cyclones, two or three of them potentially reaching severe strength. Sanma Province disaster officials have warned schools may close if water supplies fail.

REGIONAL · PACIFIC DAILY NEWS

Expert calls deep-sea mining the latest subversion of Pacific sovereignty

An expert quoted by Pacific Daily News argues deep-sea mining is the newest instrument through which outside interests erode Pacific Island states' sovereignty over their own maritime space.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Islands Business: international attention on Fiji's HIV epidemic echoes an earlier AIDS era

The surge of international attention to Fiji's HIV epidemic carries uncomfortable echoes of an earlier era of AIDS, Islands Business writes, as the region weighs a coordinated response linking drugs and HIV transmission.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Delayed New Zealand superannuation payments to reach Cook Islanders this week

The Office of the Public Service Commissioner says Cook Islanders eligible for New Zealand Government Superannuation should receive their delayed allowance this week. Cook Islanders hold New Zealand citizenship under the free association arrangement, making Wellington's payment systems a recurring administrative issue in Rarotonga.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Albanese passes Chifley's tenure and frames disruption as wartime hardship

The prime minister has surpassed the term of postwar reconstruction prime minister Ben Chifley and is now measured against Bob Hawke's record. He has linked the present moment of economic and social disruption to the hardship of wartime, a framing the Herald reads as an attempt to recast a difficult period as a national test.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

ABC analysis questions whether Albanese needs a frontbench shake-up

Anthony Albanese used a Question Time speech to defend his government on multiple fronts, which the ABC's analysis argues made matters more awkward rather than less. The piece raises whether a frontbench reshuffle is now in prospect, drawing a comparison with the 2015 image of **Tony Abbott** and **Joe Hockey** on the eve of that year's budget.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Victorian Coalition pledge to scrap Treaty draws Indigenous leaders' warning

Victorian Indigenous leaders accused Opposition Leader **Jess Wilson** of using Treaty as a political football after she vowed to scrap the state's Treaty and its elected First Peoples' body, Gellung Warl, if the Coalition wins the November 28 election. Victoria became the first state or territory to sign a modern treaty with its First Peoples last year. The Coalition would replace the self-determining model with a government department.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

The Australian asks whether Jess Wilson can restore Victoria's political clout

The Australian's Inquirer examines whether the Victorian opposition leader can rebuild the state's standing in national politics ahead of the November 28 poll. A Guardian profile the same day traces Wilson's background and the family's long involvement in Liberal politics.

AU-POLITICS · CANBERRA TIMES

Canberra Times ranks the operators who shaped October's Senate estimates

The Canberra Times has published its power list from the October 2026 round of Senate estimates, sorting senators and officials into wrecking balls and silver tongues. Estimates this round produced the AFP's analysis of radicalised children and a defence official's request for ministerial help to keep evidence off social media.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · FIJI SUN

Fiji fuel prices jump 55 cents a litre from November 1

The Fijian Competition and Consumer Commission lifted motor spirit on Viti Levu from $3.15 to *$3.70 a litre* from November 1, with diesel up 46 cents to $3.87, premix up 53 cents and kerosene up 41 cents. The commission attributed the rise to international prices driven by Middle East tensions and the Russia-Ukraine war. A 12kg LPG cylinder rises $1.10 to $43.26, and motor spirit reaches $4.29 a litre in Rotuma.

TRADE-ECONOMY · FIJI SUN

Ba Provincial Holding cuts staff from 82 to 15 and declares a dividend

Chief executive **Sitiveni Weleilakeba** told the Ba Provincial Council the company moved from no cash reserves to more than $1 million in the bank after cutting staff from 82 to 15, saving about $650,000, and renegotiating loans from eight percent to four percent interest. It declared a *$331,000* dividend in September and is weighing a three-star hotel in Lautoka.

TRADE-ECONOMY · FIJI SUN

Fiji's scholarship agency sets 2026-2031 plan after $1.4 billion in spending

Finance Minister **Esrom Immanuel** launched the Tertiary Scholarships and Loans Service strategic plan for 2026-2031 in Raiwaqa, built around student completion, graduate employment, financial accountability, and digital transformation. The government has invested more than *$1.4 billion* in scholarships, tuition assistance and student allowances through the agency since 2014.

UPCOMING

NOV 1

Fiji fuel and LPG price increases take effect nationwide

Motor spirit rises 55 to 57 cents a litre across Fiji, with the sharpest increases in maritime areas and Rotuma.

NOV 7

New Zealand general election, advance voting already open

Decides whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues, with consequences for New Zealand's defence spending and Pacific posture.

NOV 17

Eighth National Women's Expo, Vodafone Arena, Suva, to November 19

Brings about 400 women artisans from Fiji's four divisions together ahead of the 16 Days of Activism against Gender-Based Violence.

NOV 28

Victorian state election

The Coalition has pledged to scrap Victoria's Treaty and its elected First Peoples' body if it wins.

NOV 2026

Fiji's Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026 returns for a third reading vote

The NFP has directed its MPs to vote against while the People's Alliance says it has the numbers, leaving the Senate's restoration in doubt.

THE WIRE

PACIFIC-POLITICS

FIJI SUN

Fiji Law Society president says justice is out of reach for most Fijians

Graham Leung told the Fiji Law Society Convention in Denarau that institutions still operate with fragmented mandates and limited coordination. The High Court chief registrar told the same convention that of 4,283 complaints against legal practitioners recorded since 2009, *1,462 remain unresolved*.

FIJI SUN

Rabi administrator defends appointment under the Banaban Settlement Act

Rabi Council of Leaders administrator **Iakoba Karutake** said Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka** has the power to appoint an administrator under the Banaban Settlement Act, responding to Opposition MP **Premila Kumar**. He said the council was dissolved in 2013 under the Bainimarama government and administrators were appointed for about 13 years thereafter.

PNG POST-COURIER

Ok Tedi airlifts 41 tonnes of relief supplies to Tabubil

Managing director and chief executive **Kedi Ilimbit** confirmed the airlift of *41 tonnes* of emergency relief to Tabubil for drought-affected communities in the North Fly District of Western Province, following 223 tonnes delivered to the district earlier in the week.

PNG POST-COURIER

Marape renews PNG commitment to extractive industries transparency

Prime Minister **James Marape** pledged stronger government engagement with the Extractive Industries Transparency Initiative to improve transparency, accountability and management of Papua New Guinea's mineral and petroleum resources.

COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Cook Islands launches free cybersecurity e-learning programme

A free cybersecurity e-learning programme has launched in the Cook Islands, giving individuals, families and businesses tools to recognise scams and protect personal information. Fiji opened a Cyber Security Incident Reporting Portal this week.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

VANUATU DAILY POST

Mount Yasur hosts regional volcano monitoring training

Scientists and disaster management officers from across the southwest Pacific trained in volcano monitoring and disaster preparedness at Vanuatu's Mount Yasur, one of the region's most active volcanoes.

AU-POLITICS

INSIDE STORY

Inside Story argues the tech companies, not Canberra, are doing the censoring

Rys Farthing argues in Inside Story that the free speech debate over Australian online regulation misplaces its target, and that platform moderation decisions, not government rules, drive what users can say.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

AFR

From Paris to Canberra, left-wing extremists are exploiting our anger

The AFR draws a line from France's protests to Australian conditions, arguing that where France shows how violent factions capture unrest, Australia's problem is one of classification. The piece frames the distinction between protest and agitation as the operative policy question.

> **Argument:** Violent factions are exploiting public unrest, and Australia's difficulty is telling legitimate activism apart from extremist agitation.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

Read online · Past issues

You are receiving the Australia Daily Brief as a member of the CSIS Australia Chair distribution list.

This newsletter is automatically generated, so it may contain errors. Please check all information and sources before citing. To report errors or other issues, please contact Andy Lim at alim@csis.org.

generated 6:25 AM ET

↑ BACK TO TOP

© 2026 Center for Strategic and International Studies